Knowledge organiser (SUMMIT) — Planning a gallery or exhibition inquiry

Pathway: SUMMIT · Week 5 Part 1 · Big question: How do we design a structured visual inquiry plan to analyse artworks in an exhibition space?

Core studio focus

Family: Identity and studio log

Big question: How do we design a structured visual inquiry plan to analyse artworks in an exhibition space?

• Construct a four-lens Gallery inquiry Framework (Spatial context, Material execution, Tonal/Colour mechanics, and Critical impact).

• Prepare a field-sketching layout sheet with dedicated zones for thumbnail elevations, sightline maps, and detail transcriptions.

• Formulate three focused critical inquiry questions to test during next week's exhibition study.

Essential vocabulary

• inquiry framework: A structured set of visual lenses and sketching zones prepared before visiting or studying an exhibition.

• spatial layout: How artworks are positioned in relation to walls, plinths, lighting, and viewer pathways.

• execution: The technical skill and material control shown in how an artwork is physically made.

• juxtaposition: Placing two contrasting works or materials near each other to spark visual dialogue.

• critical question: An open analytical question that investigates how a work achieves its visual impact.

Three-step studio method

Step 1: Set up the four inquiry zones on my A3 sheet: I rule and title the four field-recording boxes: 1. Sightline & Lighting map, 2. 5-Value tonal Thumbnail, 3. Surface close-up, 4. Critical notes.

Step 2: Draft three critical inquiry questions: I write three analytical questions focusing on how scale, surface patina, and raking light operate in the curated collection.

Step 3: Pilot-test Zone 2 on a preview work: I run a 4-minute pilot sketch in my preview box to confirm my graphite and fineliner kit captures five tonal values rapidly.